

Response Time ROI Calculator

What is every hour of customer-response delay actually costing you? Do the math in 10 minutes.

From HitLai Institute — Module S2: “AI That Handles Your Customers”

THE RULE THE DATA BACKS UP

Every independent study of inbound customer behavior reaches the same conclusion:

- Respond in **5 minutes**: you convert at 100% of your baseline
- Respond in **1 hour**: conversion drops 10-15%
- Respond in **4 hours**: conversion drops 30-40%
- Respond **next day**: conversion drops 50-70% — the customer has already contacted a competitor

Most SMBs average 3-8 hour response times during business hours and 12-24 hours on weekends.

Meaning: **the single biggest lever on your conversion rate isn't price, pitch, or product — it's how fast someone gets a response.**

This sheet lets you put a dollar figure on that.

STEP 1: WHAT DOES YOUR RESPONSE TIME REALLY LOOK LIKE?

Don't estimate. Pull 2 weeks of inbound customer messages and measure.

Line	Your number
A. Total inbound customer inquiries in last 2 weeks (email + chat + WhatsApp + forms)	_____
B. Average time-to-first-response (median, not best case)	_____ hrs
C. % of inquiries that never got any response at all	_____ %
D. % of inquiries that received a response longer than 24 hours	_____ %

If C + D is over 25%, stop. You don't have a “response-time” problem — you have an inbox-is-on-fire problem. Come to Module S2 before doing anything else.

STEP 2: WHAT'S ONE CONVERSION WORTH?

Line	Your number
E. Average revenue per converted customer (lifetime value, or first-year if ongoing)	\$_____
F. Current inquiry-to-customer conversion rate (% of inquiries that become customers)	_____ %
G. Monthly inbound inquiry volume ($A \times \sim 2.2$ for monthly)	_____
H. Current monthly new customers ($G \times F$)	_____
I. Current monthly revenue from inbound ($H \times E$)	\$_____

STEP 3: THE COST OF DELAY

Use this conversion-loss table as your baseline (adjust if you have better data):

Current response time	Conversion loss vs. 5-min response
Under 30 min	0% (baseline)
30 min - 2 hrs	10%
2-4 hrs	25%
4-8 hrs	40%
8-24 hrs	55%
Over 24 hrs	70%

Line	Your number
J. Your % conversion loss based on B	_____ %
K. Lost monthly customers from slow response ($H \times J \div (1 - J)$) — this is what you'd gain by responding fast	_____
L. Monthly revenue left on the table ($K \times E$)	\$_____
M. Annual revenue left on the table ($L \times 12$)	\$_____

For most SMBs, M is the single largest recoverable line item in the business. And it requires zero new leads, zero new spend, zero new hires — it's already walking in the door.

STEP 4: WHAT WOULD IT COST TO FIX THIS WITH HUMANS ALONE?

Line	Your number
N. To respond within 30 minutes 9am-6pm M-F, how many dedicated response hours/week?	_____ hrs
O. To also cover evenings and weekends, add	_____ hrs
P. Total hours (N + O)	_____ hrs
Q. Hourly cost of the person who'd do it	\$_____
R. Annual cost of staffed fast-response (P × Q × 52)	\$_____

If R is less than $M \times 40\%$, hire a person. If R is more than $M \times 70\%$, stop pretending a human alone is the answer. You need AI, your team, and your channels coordinated — drafts written instantly, routine ones sent under the rules you set, unusual ones flagged for the right person.

STEP 5: THE “AI + YOUR TEAM + YOUR CHANNELS” REALITY

Line	Your number
S. % of your incoming questions that are routine/FAQ-style (your best estimate, typically 60-80%)	_____ %
T. Of those, time saved per response (5 min human vs. AI-drafted = roughly 4 min)	_____ min
U. Hours saved per month ($G \times S \times T \div 60$)	_____ hrs
V. Cost saved per month ($U \times Q$)	\$_____
W. Conversion lift from responding within 5 minutes instead of B — use J directly	_____ %
X. New monthly revenue from faster response ($K \times E$)	\$_____
Y. Total monthly upside ($V + X$)	\$_____

STEP 6: THE SUBSCRIPTION-COST HONESTY CHECK

Line	Your number
Z. Monthly subscription cost of the tool you're considering	\$_____
AA. Net monthly impact ($Y - Z$)	\$_____
BB. Break-even: how many extra customers/month must the tool generate? ($Z \div E$)	_____

If BB is under your current monthly customer count (H), and the tool only needs to lift conversion by the amount in J to break even, the math is trivial. If BB is a number bigger than your total monthly volume, move on.

THE HIDDEN COST NOBODY TALKS ABOUT

This worksheet is about revenue. There's a second cost: the person on your team who's constantly context-switching to answer inbound questions. That person was hired to sell, deliver, or manage — not to be a FAQ machine.

If you recover 20+ hours/month of their time AND capture the conversion lift in M, you're not saving money. You're redeploying a smart person to the work they were actually hired for.

WHY A PLATFORM, NOT JUST CHATGPT

ChatGPT can draft a response. It cannot:

- Know which channel the question came from
- Apply your approved answer library automatically
- Know when to send directly (FAQ, after the rules YOU set) vs. wait for a teammate (pricing, complex)
- Keep a single record across channels for your team to look back on
- Adjust when a new-to-it question comes in
- Guarantee a consistent voice across 3 team members on email, WhatsApp, web chat, and Slack

The draft is ~10% of the problem. AI, your team, and your channels running together is the other 90%.

THE HITLAI ANSWER, IN ONE LINE

AI tools, your team, your systems — running together, safely.

For customer response: every channel feeds one library. AI starts on “watches” or “suggests” — your team approves every send. After the patterns prove themselves, you let AI handle the routine ones; your team owns the exceptions. Works with what you've got — Gmail, WhatsApp, your CRM, the AI you already use. What we don't have a connector for, the platform builds automatically in minutes, reviewed before it goes live. Every step auditable.

Want help pulling your real numbers and plugging them in live? Bring your laptop to Module S2. We'll connect one channel and set up your first response flow during the session — walk out with it running.

→ hitlai.net/institute

© 2026 Bodaty LLC. All rights reserved. AICtrlNet™, HitLai™, and “Governed AI Orchestration”™ are trademarks of Bodaty LLC.